

A FRESH START
A workshop on leadership qualities with Utthan survivor-leaders' collective, member of ILFAT, in Kolkata

ILFAT
Collective for trafficking survivors in the Sunderbans, West Bengal

STARTED IN 2015

myself and this is how you can find support and recover,' is an important part of recovery," says Mondol.

Though trafficking is a huge problem in India, the data on it is limited. Figures released by the National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) include data only from anti-human trafficking units and not cases lodged by local police stations, says Kaushik Gupta, an advocate with the Calcutta High Court. According to the latest figures, over 4,700 people were trafficked across the country in 2020. Of these, 1,377 were minor boys and 845 minor girls. The data also shows a spike in some areas such as Delhi, where a 73.5 per cent rise in trafficking cases was registered in 2021. At the same time, the conviction rate across the country dropped from 27.8 per cent in 2016 to 10.6 per cent in 2020. Currently, West Bengal is among the top five states in terms of kidnappings and abductions.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"The isolation trafficking survivors feel is very strong. We need somebody who understands us"

— PIU MONDOL
President, ILFAT

While most of those who are trafficked never make it out, those who do get rescued don't have it easy either. Most of them lose precious years of their youth in shelter homes, learning no livelihood skills. Beating poverty and reintegrating with their communities becomes a deeply painful experience. Pompi Banerjee, a psychologist and senior member of Sanjog, a social impact organisation based in Kolkata that has been mentoring ILFAT's Bengal and Chhattisgarh collectives since 2016, says that prior to ILFAT's interventions, nearly three out of 10 survivors would die by suicide. Gupta agrees, and points out that the lack of legal options worsens the situation. "There is no legal right for the mental health of survivors," he says. "So, it is difficult to lodge a case when they are denied it. Then, to get a mental health evaluation, survivors have to travel very far due to unavailability of licensed doctors. Third, there is so much stigma against mental health that the survivor's family will single them out if they speak up. Even judges are not sensitive at times." Due to these hardships, many die by suicide, are lured into debt, or are trafficked yet again.

The Trafficking in Persons (Prevention, Care and Rehabilitation) Bill, 2021, may be a silver lining for survivors if it becomes law. "The law should have [provisions for] community-based mental health services, identification of mental health issues and insurance coverage for survivors diagnosed with mental health illnesses," says Banerjee. There are also recommendations for need-based livelihood training, financial inclusion, creation of jobs and access to free healthcare. However, till such rules are formalised, Gupta says, the government is the only institution that can ensure destigmatisation of mental health rights for the survivors of trafficking.

ILFAT is doing its bit to help survivors in whatever ways it can. "We have been advocating for health camps for survivors so that they have access to mental health support and there is engagement with other survivors, which will help them know their rights. At the same time, we're working towards rebuilding faith both in community and in their own selves." ILFAT is also pushing for more community-based rehabilitation, where families and society are educated so that when trafficking survivors return home, they are not stigmatised.

Today, Mondol says, she no longer sees herself as a survivor but as a survivor-leader. Through her, ILFAT has changed the lives of survivors in more ways than one. Where once survivors held their tongue and were too ashamed to speak out, today they are presenting recommendations in front of policymakers. They say they will not remain silent, even if their voices go unheard for the moment. Change, after all, doesn't come overnight. ■